

**The Missionary Church:
Rediscovering *Missional Ecclesiology* in Today's Emergent Context**
Seminar at PCA General Assembly, 2008
Preston Graham, Jr.

Introduction:

- ***Screwtape's Advice Considered***

"My dear Wormwood,

You mentioned casually in your last letter that the patient (Young Christian being tempted) has continued to attend one church, and one only, since he was converted, and that he is not wholly pleased with it. May I ask what you are about? Why have I no report on the causes of his fidelity to the parish church? Do you not realize that unless it is due to indifference it is a very bad thing? Surely you know that if a man can't be cured of church going, the next best thing is to send him all over the neighborhood looking for the church that 'suits' him until he becomes a taster or connoisseur of churches.

Your affectionate uncle, SCREWTAPE

- ***The "Emergent" Landscape Briefly Described and Analyzed***

- **Thesis: The Rediscovery of an "High-Church/High Gospel" Missional Ecclesiology as essential to Biblical Salvation**

Rediscover?

Acts 2 (43-47)

Awe came upon everyone... All who believed were together and had all things in common; they would sell their possessions and goods and distribute the proceeds to all, as any had need. Day by day, as they spent much time together with one accord in the temple, they broke bread at home and ate their food with glad and generous hearts, praising God and having favor with all the people. And day by day the Lord added to them those who were being saved.

Cyprian, Bishop of Carthage (AD 250)

She is one mother, plentiful in the results of fruitfulness: from her womb we are born, by her milk we are nourished, by her spirit we are animated . . . Whoever is separated from the Church . . . is separated from the promises to the Church; nor can he who forsakes the Church of Christ attain to the rewards of Christ . . . He can no longer have God for his Father, who has not the Church for his mother. If any one could escape who was outside the ark of Noah, then he also may escape who shall be outside of the Church.¹

Augustine

Victorinus, said to Simplicianus, not openly, but secretly, and as a friend, 'Know thou that I am a Christian,' To which he replied, 'I will not believe it, nor will I rank you among the Christians unless I see you in the Church of Christ'²

John Calvin

They therefore are insane who, neglecting this means, hope to be perfect in Christ, as is the case with fanatics, who pretend to secret revelations of the Spirit; and the proud who content themselves with the private reading of the Scripture, and imagine they do not need the ministry of the church. From her womb we are born, by her milk we are nourished, by her spirit we are animated... Whoever is separated from the Church is separated from the promises to the Church. Nor can he who forsakes the Church of Christ attain to the rewards of Christ... Beyond the pale of the Church, no forgiveness of sins, no salvation, can be hoped for ... the paternal favor of God and the special evidence of spiritual life are confined to his peculiar people, and hence the abandonment of the Church is always fatal.³

¹ Cyprian, Bishop of Carthage, *On the Unity of the Church* (c. a.d. 250), emphasis added; available at www.philthompson.net/pages/library/unity.html (accessed Aug. 2004)

² Augustine, *Confessions*, VIII.iii.4

³ John Calvin, *Institutes* 4.1.4

Westminster

*The catholic or universal Church... gathered into one, under Christ the Head thereof... is... the body, the fullness of Him that filleth all in all. The visible Church... is the kingdom of the Lord Jesus Christ, the house and family of God, out of which there is no ordinary possibility of salvation.*⁴

Lesslie Newbigin

*Just as we insist that a Church which has ceased to be a mission has lost the essential character of a Church, so must we also say that a mission which is not at the same time truly a Church is not a true expression of the divine apostolate. An unchurchly mission is as much a monstrosity as an unmissionary church.*⁵

I. The Construction of "High-Church" Biblical-Theology of Missions and The R/H Gospel of Presence

Resources:

- Preston Graham Jr. "A Sacramental Theology of the Gospel: Rediscovering the Saving Presence of God In The Church", *The Assembling Of Ourselves Together: Ecclesiology In The 21st Century*, John Vance edited, (Rock Tavern, NY: WPC Books, 2005)
- Greg Beale, "Eden, the Temple, And the Church's Mission in the New Creation" (JETS 48/1 (March 2005) 5-31.
- Edmund Clowney, *The Biblical Theology of the Church* (Article published at The Biblical Theology Briefings - beginningwithmoses.org) c.f. Toward A Biblical Theology of the Church Philadelphia: Presbyterian and Reformed, 1969

OC Survey

Eden (Gen.1:1-2... Gen.1:27-28... Gen.3:8, 24 [Lev.23:3, Ex.26:1])

Bethel (Gen.12:9, 28:10-18, 31:13)

Moses (Psm. 46, c.f. Gen.15, 26:24, Ex. 29:42, Dt. 12:5. Lev. 22:3,

*The Bible is not the story of ideas about God, but the story of the people of God...the gospel does not come to each of us in isolation. It comes to us through a particular book and through a particular fellowship... it is a false spirituality, divorced from the whole teaching of the Bible which regards this visible and continuing church as of subordinate importance for the life of Christ... God meets us through his people here and now in the form of an actual invitation into the fellowship of a body of people calling themselves one Church?*⁶

NC Survey

John 1:31-32... 6:56... 14-20...

Luke 3:22... Acts 1:5... Acts 2:41-42... Acts 9:31

1 Cor.3:16... 2Cor.6:16

Rev. (20-21)

*Paul dares to assert [that] the community is the place where God dwells. "Do you not know," he asks, "that you [plural] are God's temple and that God's Spirit dwells in you [plural]?" (5:16). To read this last sentence as though it spoke of the Spirit dwelling in the body of the individual Christian would be to miss the force of Paul's audacious metaphor: the apostolically founded community takes the place of the Jerusalem temple as the place where the glory of God resides.*⁷

Ephesians: The Ascended Ministry of Christ and Temple Spirituality (Eph. 1:22-23, 2:11ff, 4:16, etc)

- the church, which is his body, the fullness of him who fills all in all...
- Once... but now (x2)
- tabernacle of God (vs. 22... c.f. Psm.46:4, etc)

⁴ WCF 25.1-2

⁵ *Household of God*, p. 147

⁶ Leslie Newbigin, *The Reunion of the Church*, (NY, NY: Harper & Row, 1948)p. 27, 29

⁷ Richard B. Hayes, *Ecclesiology and Ethics in 1Corinthians*, (located on the web.) N.p.

- joined together (organization/church planting)... (vs. 20... cf. 4:16)
- IN, not of, for the world (Eph. 5)

The ascension, (not the resurrection or parousia) thus becomes the climax of Jesus-history and the eschatological event fulfilling all the hopes of Israel. ... The kind of ecclesiology we, wish to do is quite impossible, then, without careful attention to the ascension... the church is marked off from the world... by its mysterious union with one whose life, though lived for the world, involves a genuine break with it.⁸

II. The Construction of "High-Gospel" Biblical Theology of Missions and Missional Ecclesiology

Resources:

- Preston Graham Jr. *Lesslie Newbigin's Missional Ecclesiology Explored and The Centrality of the Church as A Social Strategy* (unpublished but located at www.christpresnewhaven.org/StudyCenterLinks.html)
- Thomas F. Torrance, *Royal Priesthood*, (Edinburgh: Oliver and Boyd, 1955)
- Darrell Guder, "The Church as Missional Community," in Mark Husbands & Daniel Treier, eds., *The Community of the Word: Toward an Evangelical Ecclesiology*, Downers Grove: InterVarsity Press and Leicester: Apollos, 2005, pp. 114-128
- Lesslie Newbigin, c.f.
 - *The Gospel in Today's Global City*, Selly Oak Occasional Paper No. 16 (1997)
 - *Can the West Be Converted?* in *The Best of Bishop Lesslie Newbigin from the International Bulletin of Missionary Research* (January 1987), 1998.
 - "Religious Pluralism: A Missiological Approach" (1993) and published in *Theology of Religions: Christianity and Other Religions* (Roma: Pontifical Gregorian University), p. 227-244.
 - *The Gospel in a Pluralistic Society*, Especially Chapter 10 & 18, "The Congregation as Hermeneutic to the Gospel"
- Tim Keller, *The Missional Church, Evangelistic Worship*

Ecclesial IS Missionary!

Such an ecclesiology pays particularly close attention to the "as" and the "so" in John's missional summary: "As my Father has sent me, so I send you." God's incarnational action in history provides the church the content of its witness and defines how it is to be carried out.⁹

The church is not the source of witness, it is the locus of witness.... The presence of a new reality, the presence in the shared life of the church of the spirit who is the anointed of the kingdom, has become possible because of what Jesus has done, because of his incarnation, his ministry as the obedient child of his father, his suffering and death, his resurrection, AND his ascension into heaven and his session at the right hand of God... Its visible embodiment will be a community that lives by this story, a community whose existence is visibly defined in the regular rehearsing and reenactment of the story which has given it birth, the story of the self-emptying of God in the ministry of life, death and resurrection of Jesus. Its visible center as a continuing social entity is that weekly repeated event in which believers share bread and wine as Jesus commanded, as his pledge to them and their pledge to him that they are one with him in his passion and one with him in his victory...¹⁰

*I confess that I have come to feel that the primary reality of which we have to take account in seeking for a Christian impact on public life is the Christian congregation.. How is it possible that the gospel should be credible, that people should come to believe that the power which has the last word in human affairs is represented by a man hanging on a cross? I am suggesting that the only answer, the only hermeneutic of the gospel, is a congregation of men and women who believe it and live by it... This community has at its heart the remembering and rehearsing of his words and deeds, and the sacraments given by him through which it is enabled both to engraft new members into its life through the body broken and the lifeblood poured out. **It exists in him and for him.** He is the center of its life. Its character is given to it, when it is true to its nature, not by the characters of its members but by HIS character. Insofar as it is true to its calling, it becomes the place where men and women and children find that the gospel gives them the framework of understanding, the lenses through which they are able to understand and cope with the world."¹¹*

Ecclesial Evangelism and Conversion

⁸ Douglas Farrow, *Ascension and Ecclesia* (p. 11, 17)

⁹ Darrell Guder, *The Church As Missional Community*

¹⁰ Lesslie Newbigin, *The Gospel in a Pluralistic Society*, Ch. 10, p. 120

¹¹ Lesslie Newbigin, *The Gospel in a Pluralistic Society*, Chapter 18

- **Early Church Revisited**

Pagan converts to the [Christian] mainstream did not, for the most part, first understand the faith and then decide to become Christians; rather, the process was reversed: they first decided and then they understood. More precisely, they were first attracted by the Christian community and form of life... they submitted themselves to prolonged catechetical instruction in which they practiced new modes of behavior and learned the stories of Israel and their fulfillment in Christ. Only after they had acquired proficiency in the alien Christian language and form of life were they deemed able intelligently and responsibly to profess the faith, to be baptized.¹²

- **Augustine's Confessions revisited**

We were baptized, and all anxiety as to our past life fled away.¹³

Evangelistic Communalism and Ethics as "Witness"

Ecclesial Ethics and Cultural Transformation (c.f. Preston Graham,

- **The Post-Liberal Contribution: "Let the church be the church"**

The church must be a sample of the kind of humanity which, for example, economic and racial differences are surmounted. Only then will it have anything to say to the society that surrounds it about how those difference must be dealt with.¹⁴

The time has therefore come to bear witness to the specific virtues of the Christian life through reference to its setting within the church under the guidance of Holy Scripture and the lordship of Jesus Christ. Christian witness in this social context bears the character not of seeking common ground with those who dwell extra muros ecclesiae [outside the walls of the church] but of articulating a vision that is distinctively and sometimes counter to the prevailing culture."¹⁵

- **A Reformed Pedigree**

- **5th Century Augustine (City of God)**
- **16th Century John Calvin's Geneva (Institutes, 4.20.1,**
- **16th century The Scottish Reformation (1578 Scottish Second Book of Discipline and the famous One Hundred and Eleven Propositions**
- **19th Century Border State Presbyterians (Civil War Movement of Dissent against politization of the Church, e.g. Stuart Robinson, Boarder State "Declaration and Testimony")¹⁶**
- **20th Century Confessing Church, Barman Declaration**

- **The Significance of Ecclesial Based Mercy Ministry (c.f. CPC policy)**

- **Evangelistic Sacramentalism... WCF carefully observed!**

We expect salvation from him — not because he stands aloof from us, but because engrafting us into his body he not only makes us partakers of all his benefits, but also of himself... you become a member of him, and hence one with him... It will never do to separate Christ from us, nor us from him; but we must, with both hands, keep firm hold of that alliance by which he has riveted us to himself. This the Apostle teaches us: "The body is dead because of sin; but the spirit is life because of righteousness," (Rom. 8:10)... He tells us that the condemnation which we of ourselves deserve is annihilated by the salvation of Christ; and to confirm this he employs the argument to which I have referred, viz., that Christ is not external to us, but dwells in us; and not only unites us to himself by an undivided bond of fellowship, but by a wondrous communion brings us daily into closer connection, until he becomes altogether one with us.

¹² George Lindbeck, *The Nature of Doctrine*, p. 132c.f. c.f. Above redemptie historical survey and especially the story of the early church in Act 2:1-47, note especially vs. 44-47, and then a more theological discourse about the relation of faith to participation in the life of God in, with and through the "temple" of the New Testament church in Ephesians 2:1- 22.

¹³ Augustine, *The Confessions* (New York: Alfred A. Knopf/Random House, 2001), 9.6.

¹⁴ Yoder, John Howard, *The Politics of Jesus*, 2nd Edition (Eerdmans: Grand Rabids, Michigan, (1972), p. 150-152.

¹⁵ David Ferguson, *Community, Liberalism and Christian Ethics*, (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1998), p.1-2.

¹⁶ C.f. Preston Graham Jr., *A Kingdom Not of This World: Stuart Robinson' Struggle to Distinguish the Sacred From the Secular During the American Civil War*, Macon: Mercy University Press, 2002)

*no extent of space interferes with the boundless energy of the Spirit, which transfuses life into us from the flesh of Christ.*¹⁷

- **Evangelistic Confessionalism**

Let us in Heaven's name drag out the Divine drama from under the dreadful accumulation of slipshod thinking and trashy sentiment heaped upon it, and set it on an open stage to startle the world into some sort of vigorous reaction. IF the pious are the first to be shocked, so much the worse for the pious — others will enter the Kingdom of Heaven before them. IF all men are offended because of Christ, let them be offended; but where is the sense of their being offended at something that is not Christ and is nothing like Him. WE do Him singularly little honor by watering down his personality till it could not offend a fly. Surely it is not the business of the church to adapt Christ to men, but to adapt men to Christ.

Ecumenism from the Perspective of Ecclesial Mission Explored

*For me, that basis when I am pressed to define it always lies in the actual experience of the missionary encounter, the encounter with the man, for instance, in the streets of an Indian city who challenges, you the foreigner, to say what right you have to bring the name of a foreign God, of a foreign religion into the land of India. One replies to such a challenge by trying to show him how the name of Jesus is not the name of the leader of one religion, is not the name that we in the west give to God but is the name of the one decisive and final revelation of God the man, the One who alone has brought reconciliation between man and God and thereby created the possibility of reconciliation between man and man. But when one replies that way, the answer always comes back: content with the Name of Jesus? You do not believe that the Name of Jesus is the all sufficient Name because all of you have to add something else to that Name before you are satisfied. We have to conclude that what you are bringing to us is not the one Name of which you speak; it is in... a whole series of names — the fragments of western European culture which have been projected into our world by the colonial expansion of the 19th century.*¹⁸

- **A Confessional, Sacramental, Communal (High Church) model vs. Traditional OR Non-Traditional (Low Church) Proposal**

I believe that true ecumenism is not something which is evading the question of truth. It is something which is facing, at a deeper level, the question "What is the truth?" Is the truth ultimately in the Name of Jesus and there alone, or is the truth only to be known by adding something else in the Name of Jesus? The real issue which this missionary encounter raises is the question, "What is the true confession?" What does it mean to confess Jesus today?"¹⁹

- **An Organic, Multi-Traditional-Mono Congregational Proposal**

*For the perfecting of the life of the whole body, the Church of South India needs the heritage of each of the uniting Churches, and each of those Churches will, it is hoped, not lose the continuity of its own life, but preserve that life enriched by the union with itself of the other two Churches. The Church of South India is thus formed by a combination of different elements each bringing its contribution to the whole, and not by the absorption of any one by any other. It is, therefore, also a comprehensive Church; and its members, firmly holding the fundamentals of the faith and order of the Church Universal, are allowed wide freedom of opinion in all other matters, and wide freedom of action in such differences of practice as are consistent with the general framework of the Church as one organized body.*²⁰

Conclusion:

One of our great allies at present is the Church itself. Do not misunderstand me. I do not mean the Church as we see her spread out through all time and space and rooted in eternity, terrible as an army with banners. That, I confess, is a spectacle which makes our boldest tempters uneasy. But fortunately it is quite invisible to these humans.

Screwtape to Wormwood

¹⁷ First quote: Jean Calvin, *Institutes of the Christian Religion* 1559, ed. J. T. McNeill and F.L. Battles (Philadelphia: Westminster, 1960), III.2.24. c.f. Ronald S. Wallace, *Calvin's Doctrine of the Word and Sacrament*, (Edinburgh: Oliver and Boyd, 1953). Second Quote: John Calvin, *Corpus Reformatorum*, 37:4

¹⁸ Recounted in J.E. Lesslie Newbigin "Missions In An Ecumenical Perspective," (1962) P. 9. "NA"

¹⁹ E. Lesslie Newbigin, *Missions In An Ecumenical Perspective* 1962 p. 9 "NA"

²⁰ Lesslie Newbigin, "The Nature of the Unity that We Seek": 1. From the Church of South India (1957) *Religion in Life*, 26, 2 (1957): 181-190. p. 2.